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# I'm Fine. (I'm Not.)

The anxiety reset for the woman who holds it  
together for everyone — and falls apart alone.

START HERE

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# You're not fine. You're a master at looking fine.

You answer the emails, pack the lunches, smile in the meeting, ask everyone how *they're* doing. And then you lie awake at 2 a.m. with your heart pounding, running every worst-case in HD. From the outside you're the calm, capable one. Inside, you're white-knuckling it through every single day.

That's high-functioning anxiety, and it's invisible *because* you're so good at the mask. But "managing it" is not the same as being okay — it's just exhausting in private. This isn't "have you tried yoga." It's the real, fast tools to drop the spike in 90 seconds, untangle the spinning, and the exact words for when you can't hold the mask up anymore.

## THE COST OF "FINE"

Every time you say "I'm fine" when you're not, you teach everyone — including yourself — that your struggle doesn't count. The mask keeps you safe and keeps you alone. We're going to crack it on purpose, in the right places.

## STEP 1

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# The mask audit

High-functioning anxiety hides in plain sight. Tick what's true — this is the part of you no one sees:

- **Outwardly:** calm, capable, the "strong one," always has it handled, says yes, over-prepares, over-delivers.
- **Inside:** racing thoughts, replaying conversations, certain you said the wrong thing, bracing for disaster.
- **In your body:** tight chest, clenched jaw, shoulders at your ears, churning stomach, can't sit still, can't take a full breath.
- **At night:** exhausted but wired, the 2 a.m. spiral, dreading tomorrow before today's even over.
- **The tell:** people would be shocked to know how anxious you actually are.

### NAME WHERE IT LIVES

Anxiety hits your body before your thoughts. "I notice my chest is tight" tells your brain you're observing, not in danger — and the spike starts to ease. Naming it is the first crack in the mask.

## STEP 2

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# The 90-second reset

When the wave hits, run this. It works *with* your nervous system instead of arguing with your thoughts:

- 1 **Double inhale, long exhale.** Two quick breaths in through the nose, one slow breath out through the mouth. Repeat 4x. It's the fastest known way to physically calm the body — faster than any thought.
- 2 **5-4-3-2-1.** Name 5 things you see, 4 you can touch, 3 you hear, 2 you smell, 1 you taste. It drags you out of the spiral and back into the actual room.
- 3 **Feet on the floor.** Press them down hard. Say: "I am here. I am safe right now." Anxiety lives in the future. Right now is almost always okay.

### THE TRUTH ABOUT THE SPIKE

A panic surge peaks and falls in about 90 seconds if you don't feed it. You don't have to fix the worry — you have to ride the wave without grabbing it. It will pass. It always passes.

### STEP 3

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## The worry sort

Anxiety treats every worry as urgent and true. Dump them out, then drop each into one box. Most won't survive the sort.

### **I can act on it**

There's one small step. Write it — that's tomorrow's job, not tonight's 2 a.m. job.

### **Can't control it**

Not mine to carry. Name it and physically set it down.

### **Not even likely**

The "what if" fear invented. Thank it for trying to protect you, and release it.

### **THE REFRAME**

A worry you can't act on, can't control, and that probably won't happen is not a task — it's a feeling wearing a costume. You don't have to solve a costume.

## STEP 4

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# When you can't hold the mask up

You don't always have to perform "fine." Letting the right people see the truth is how you stop being alone in it. The exact words:

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“ **TO YOUR PARTNER**

I'm not okay right now — my anxiety is loud today. I don't need you to fix it. I just need you to know, and to take one thing off my plate.

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“ **TO YOUR KIDS (age-appropriate)**

Mommy's feeling some big worried feelings today. It's not your fault, and I'm taking care of it. Everyone feels this way sometimes.

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“ **AT WORK / TO A FRIEND**

I'm running on empty and a little overwhelmed this week. Can I get [an extension / a hand / just to vent for five minutes]?

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“ **TO YOURSELF**

"Fine" is not the goal. Honest and steady is. I'm allowed to not be okay and still be capable.

## For the nights it wakes you.

When the spiral pulls you out of sleep, don't fight it — route it:

- **Brain dump.** Everything looping, onto paper by the bed. Out of your head, onto the page, where it can't grow.
- **One tomorrow-action.** Pick the single most useful thing and write it down. The rest waits for daylight.
- **Long exhales + body scan.** From your toes up, soften each part, pairing it with the slow breath out from Step 2.
- **Permission:** "Nothing gets solved at 2 a.m. My only job right now is to rest."

### READ THIS WHEN IT'S BAD

You are not your anxiety. You're the calm watching the storm. The storm is loud, but it is not in charge — and it is not the truth. It's just weather, and weather passes.

If anxiety is constant or running your life, that's worth real support — please talk to a doctor or therapist. Asking for help is strength, not failure.

# You don't have to hold it all. Just breathe.

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Two breaths in, one long breath out. Sort the worry. Crack the mask with the people who've earned the real you. You were never supposed to be a calm, capable machine — you're a person, and you're allowed to be one out loud. The storm passes. You don't.

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